

Introduction & Source of Inspiration

After entering the university stage, the **pressure** of study and life has been increasing due to highly specialized courses, complex research tasks, and being far from home. With a **heavy workload** and **limited social time**, I found it difficult to establish meaningful **connections** with others. Consequently, I harbored prolonged **negative emotions** and experienced a profound sense of **loneliness** during that period.

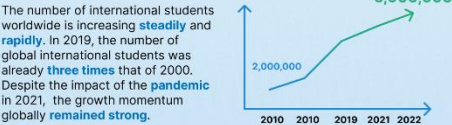
To seek solace, I made an effort to proactively engage in communication with others. As the breadth and depth of my interactions expanded, I discovered that many peers shared **similar** feelings and struggles. Particularly those **studying abroad** or **adapting to cultural differences** within our joint Chinese-foreign institution faced additional challenges.

With a deeper exploration of the issue of loneliness and based on my comprehensive understanding of its consequences, such as **reduced learning efficiency** and **persistent low mood**, I resolved to actively explore solutions to address this problem. **My goal** was to provide **support** for students experiencing **similar difficulties**.

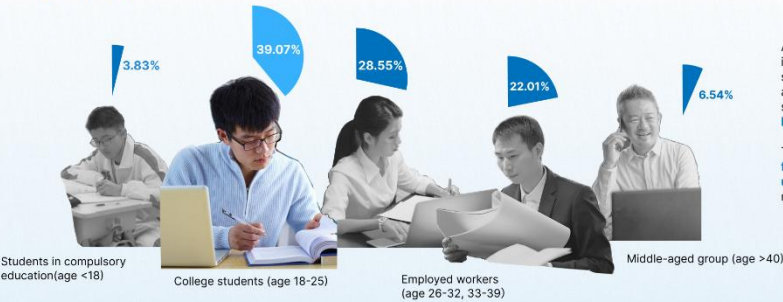
Ranking by the number of students in the country of origin



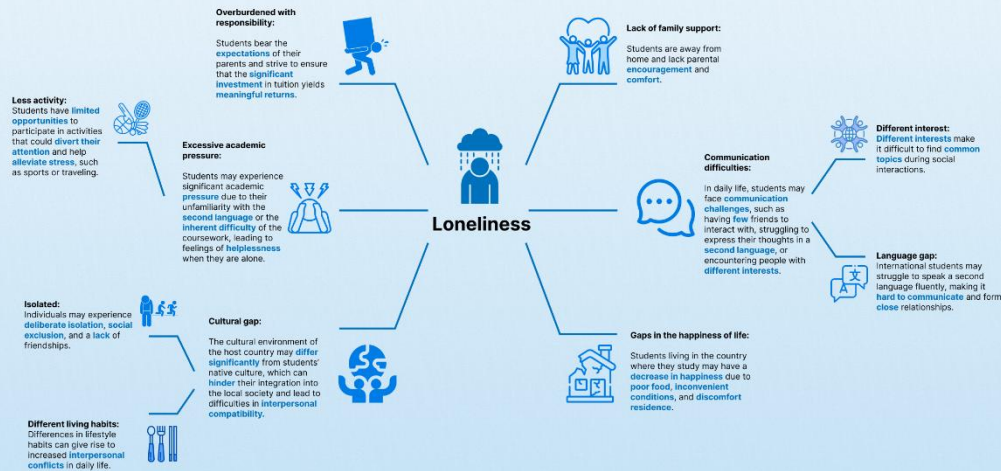
Growth trend of international students worldwide



Age proportion of international students

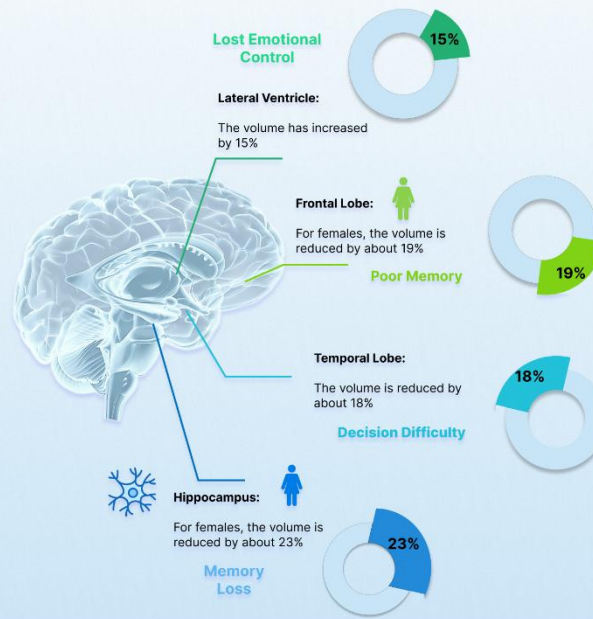


The causes of loneliness

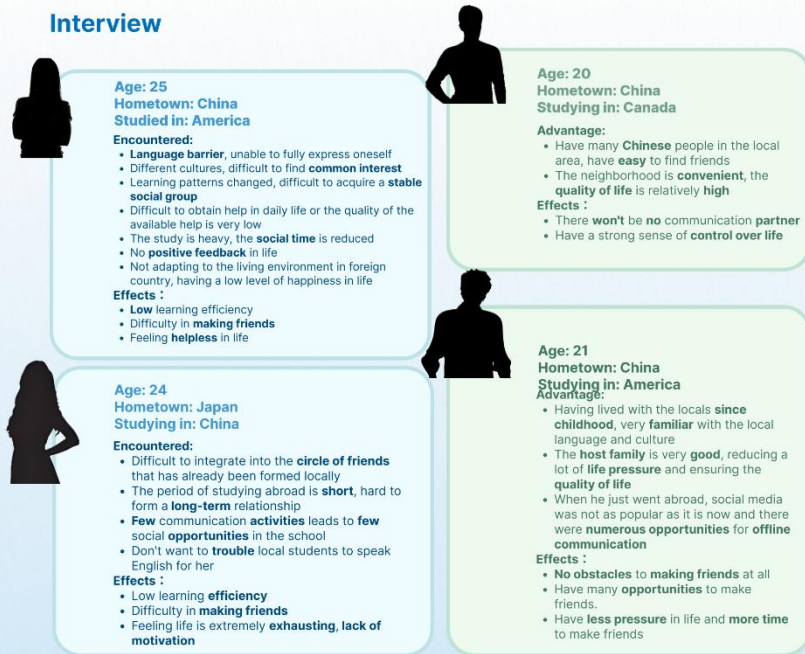


The effects and damage of loneliness on the brain

Chronic loneliness can negatively affect **brain function**. Damage in areas like the **lateral ventricle**, **frontal lobe**, **temporal lobe**, and **hippocampus** has been found to varying degrees. These changes may result in **memory problems**, **decision-making difficulties**, **emotional instability**, and other issues that impact students' studies and daily life.



Interview



Conclusion

- Interviews with international students indicate that loneliness frequently stems from **cultural adaptation challenges, language barriers**, and **limited social connections**. Additional contributing factors include **academic pressure, homesickness, and lifestyle adjustments**.
- **Participating in social activities, engaging in new experiences, and maintaining familiar routines** can help alleviate these feelings. Emotional support and intercultural understanding are essential in this process.
- Notably, the development of **close friendships** and access to **social support networks** have been found to significantly enhance daily life and reduce feelings of loneliness. **Peer support** enables students to better cope with common challenges.
- Once **close social connections** are established, many related issues tend to improve. For instance, close friendships provide emotional and practical support, which contributes to an improved quality of life and a reduced sense of isolation.

Online Survey

Xiaohongshu, a popular Chinese social media platform, hosts numerous **personal reflections** and **discussions** regarding the experiences of **loneliness** among international students.



"After studying abroad, I realized how **few opportunities** there are to connect with others through daily life or academics. In China during undergrad, we lived in dorms with 4-6 people and often did **group activities**—forming **long-term** bonds was **easy**. But overseas, I **rarely** get to spend extended time with classmates. Most study at home, and there's **little chance or environment** to explore shared interests deeply, so relationships tend to stay **shallow** or **short-term**."

"Yeah, same here. Most of the friends I still keep in touch with are **roommates from middle school** in China. Making new friends on my own now feels **really difficult**. I stayed abroad during the holidays and **cooked for myself**, while others posted pictures with their friend groups—I **felt left out**. I also find it awkward to keep friendships going **just around** eating or drinking. What's the point? Making friends with locals is **even harder** because of **cultural gaps**."

"My classmates and I **don't share many common interests**, and our conversations **rarely go beyond class topics**. Once the semester ends, we tend to lose all contact—classmates feel more like **temporary contacts than real friends**. I still struggle with enjoying time alone. Every time I go out by myself, I feel very **uncomfortable**. Although humans are social animals, I consider myself 90% introverted. The only people who reach out to me are group project partners."

"Sometimes I just can't make friends because I'm **not good at expressing myself**. I have all these thoughts and feelings bottled up, but I can't put them into words... It's super **frustrating** and **painful**."

Factors of the Difficulty in Making Friends



Research findings indicate that international students **commonly** encounter **significant** challenges in **forming friendships**. Whether it involves identifying individuals with **shared interests** or **accessing opportunities** for social interaction, students consistently report these aspects as major obstacles.

Therefore, I decided to develop a **product** designed to assist college students in building **close friendships**. This tool not only helps students connect with **like-minded** peers but also ensures the **authenticity** of these connections, while offering **additional opportunities** for social interaction through a **companion APP**.

Persona



Five-dimensional Personality Table

This table presents **animal-based** personality profiles defined by five core traits: **Expressiveness**, **Energy**, **Orderliness**, **Intellecion**, and **Empathy**. The system compares a user's **interest-derived personality vector** with the **preset vectors of these animal personas** to identify the most **similar match**, thereby making personality understanding **intuitive**, **visual**, and **engaging**.

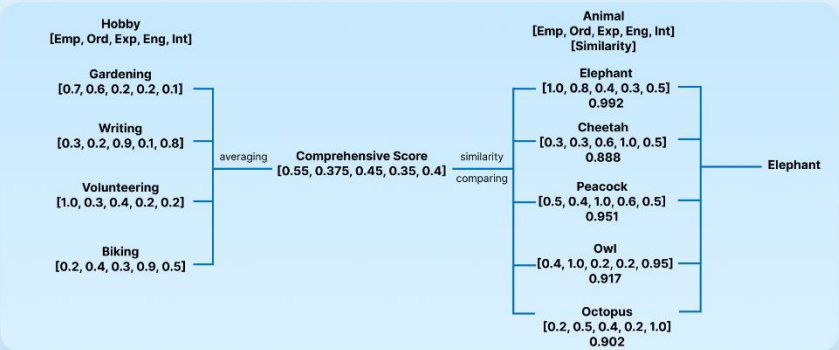
Expressiveness		Expressive, stylish, enjoys being noticed	
Energy		Energetic, loves fast movement, driven by instinct	
Orderliness		Logical, organized thinker, very rational	
Intellecion		Highly intelligent, solves complex problems, curious and driven to explore.	
Empathy		Caring and gentle, values family bonds, and looks after others	

UserVector_i = $\frac{1}{N} \sum_{j=1}^N \text{Interest}_{ij}[i]$

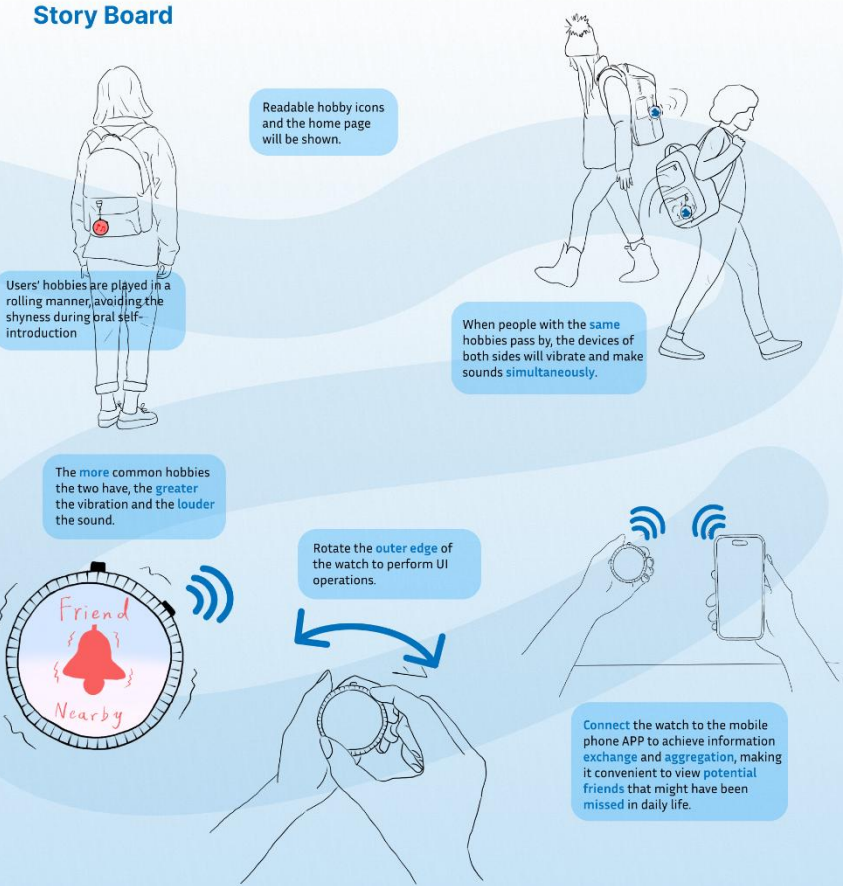
sim($\vec{A}, \vec{B}$) = $\frac{\sum_{i=1}^n A_i B_i}{\sqrt{\sum_{i=1}^n A_i^2} \cdot \sqrt{\sum_{i=1}^n B_i^2}}$

User Vector: **Average** of selected interests' trait scores.

Similarity: **Cosine similarity** between user and animal vectors.



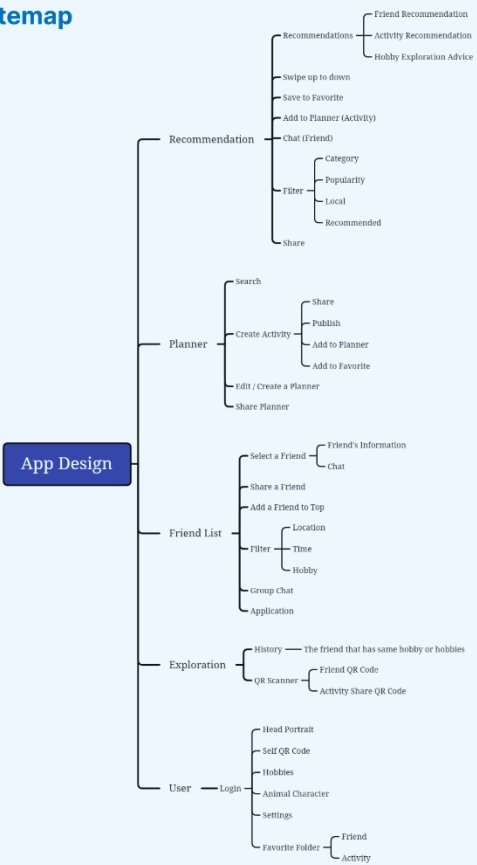
Story Board



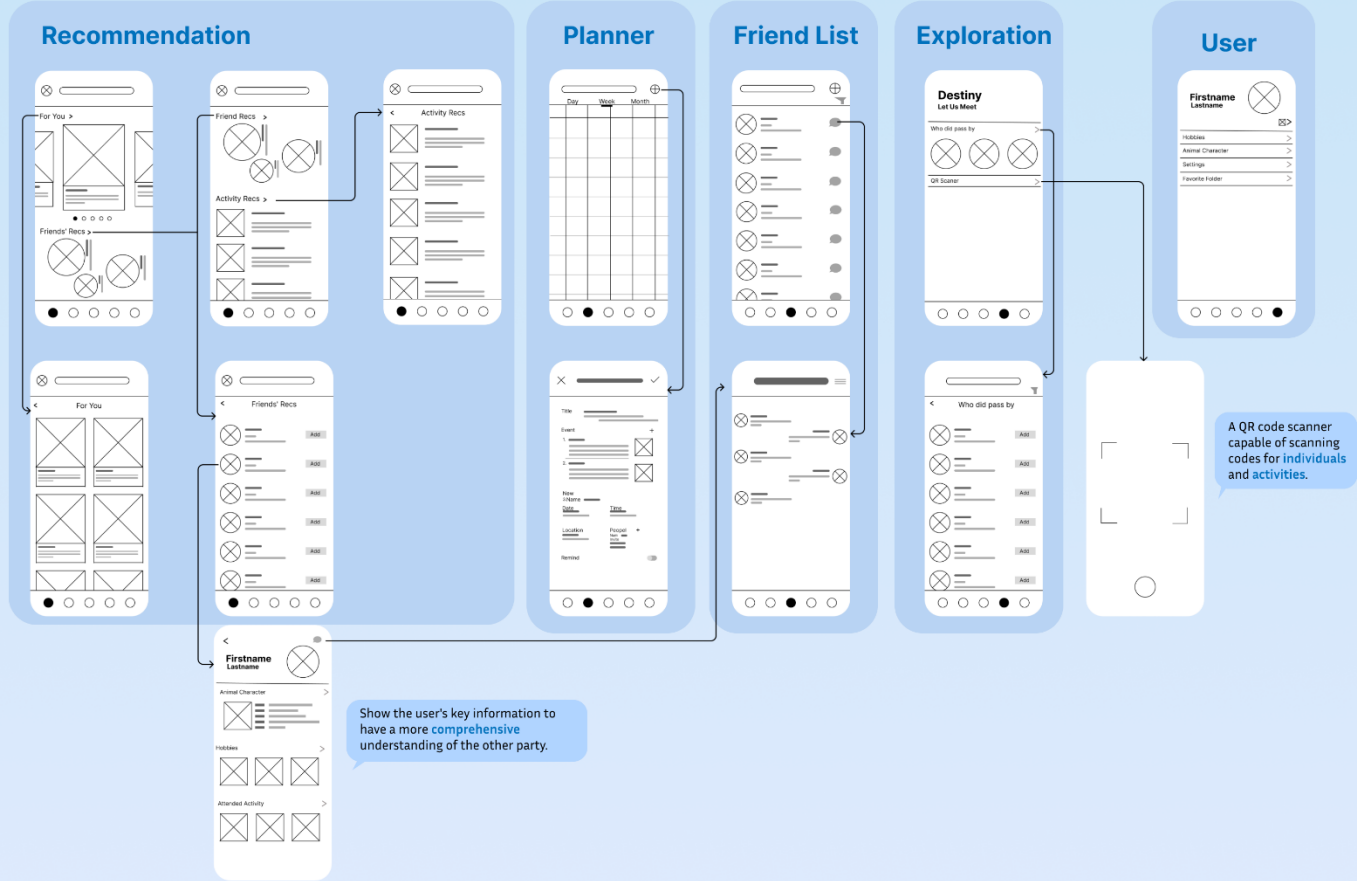
Product Rendering



Sitemap



Low-fidelity



Interface Mockup

Recording

The app will **record** people with the same hobbies who pass by it through the **widget watch**.

Viewing

Detailed personal personality analysis and activity records

Arranging

The activities can be **customized** with **high freedom** and uploaded to the community to be carried out **together with friends**

Recommendations

Personalized recommendation on friends, activities.

Comprehensive recommendations, including hobbies, activities and friends. Special recommendations are only **for you**.

Activities where people are present together offer opportunities for **making friends** or **enhancing relationships**.

Choose the one you want most from the **vast number** of recommendations.

STEP 1

The work **pressure** is just **overwhelming** !!! I don't have any **time** left for socializing at all!
I feel so **lonely**...



STEP 2

Connect with Phone
& Setting Hobby List



STEP 3

Connect with Phone &
Setting Hobby List

STEP 4

Shared-Hobby
Friend Passing By



STEP 5

Arranging Activity
& Deepen the
Friendship